Common Symptoms and When to See a Doctor

Headaches

Headaches are one of the most common health complaints. Most headaches are not serious and can be managed with rest, hydration, and over-the-counter pain relief.

Types of Headaches

- **Tension headaches**: The most common type, often described as a band of pressure around the head. Usually caused by stress, poor posture, or eye strain.
- **Migraines**: Intense, throbbing pain usually on one side of the head. May include nausea, sensitivity to light and sound, and visual disturbances.
- **Cluster headaches**: Severe pain around one eye or one side of the head, occurring in clusters over weeks or months.
- **Sinus headaches**: Pain and pressure in the forehead, cheeks, and around the eyes, often accompanying sinus infections.

When to See a Doctor for Headaches

Seek medical attention if you experience:

- Sudden, severe headache (worst headache of your life)
- Headache with fever, stiff neck, confusion, or seizures
- Headache after a head injury
- Chronic headaches that worsen over time
- Headache with vision changes, speech difficulties, or weakness

Source: Mayo Clinic, National Institutes of Health (NIH)

Fever

A fever is a temporary increase in body temperature, often due to infection. Normal body temperature is approximately 98.6°F (37°C), though it varies throughout the day.

Common Causes

- Viral infections (cold, flu, COVID-19)
- Bacterial infections
- Heat exhaustion
- Certain medications
- Immunizations

Managing Fever

- Stay hydrated with water, clear broths, and electrolyte drinks
- Rest adequately
- Wear lightweight clothing
- Keep room temperature comfortable
- Consider fever-reducing medications as recommended by a healthcare provider

When to See a Doctor for Fever

- Temperature above 103°F (39.4°C) in adults
- Fever lasting more than 3 days
- Fever with severe headache, stiff neck, or rash
- Fever in infants under 3 months (any fever warrants immediate medical attention)
- Fever with difficulty breathing or persistent vomiting

Source: Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), Mayo Clinic

Cough

A cough is a natural reflex that helps clear the airways. It can be acute (lasting less than 3 weeks) or chronic (lasting more than 8 weeks).

Common Causes

- Upper respiratory infections (common cold, flu)
- Allergies and postnasal drip
- Asthma
- Gastroesophageal reflux disease (GERD)
- Environmental irritants (smoke, pollution)

Self-Care for Cough

- Stay well hydrated
- Use honey (for adults and children over 1 year) to soothe throat
- Use a humidifier to add moisture to the air
- Avoid irritants like smoke and strong odors

- Elevate your head while sleeping
When to See a Doctor for Cough
- Cough lasting more than 3 weeks
- Coughing up blood or bloody mucus
- Cough with shortness of breath or wheezing
- Cough accompanied by unexplained weight loss
- High fever with cough
Source: World Health Organization (WHO), NIH
Fatigue
Fatigue is a feeling of constant tiredness or weakness that can be physical, mental, or both. It is a symptom, not a disease.
Common Causes
- Lack of sleep or poor sleep quality
- Stress and anxiety
- Poor nutrition or dehydration
- Sedentary lifestyle
- Anemia
- Thyroid disorders
- Depression
Managing Fatigue
- Aim for 7-9 hours of sleep per night
- Maintain a regular sleep schedule
- Exercise regularly (at least 150 minutes of moderate activity per week)
- Eat a balanced diet rich in fruits, vegetables, and whole grains
- Stay hydrated
- Manage stress through relaxation techniques
When to See a Doctor for Fatigue
- Persistent fatigue lasting more than 2 weeks despite adequate rest
- Fatigue accompanied by unexplained weight loss or gain
- Fatigue with shortness of breath or chest pain
- Fatigue with fever that doesn't resolve
- Fatigue affecting daily activities and quality of life
Source: NIH, Mayo Clinic, WHO
Stomach Pain
Stomach or abdominal pain is discomfort felt between the chest and pelvic area. It can range from mild to severe and may be acute or chronic.
Common Causes
- Indigestion or gas
- Food poisoning
- Gastritis
- Constipation
- Menstrual cramps
- Gastroesophageal reflux disease (GERD)
- Urinary tract infections
Self-Care for Stomach Pain
- Eat smaller, more frequent meals
- Avoid spicy, fatty, or acidic foods
- Stay hydrated
- Try gentle heat (warm compress) on the abdomen
- Avoid lying down immediately after eating
When to See a Doctor for Stomach Pain
- Severe or sudden abdominal pain
- Pain accompanied by fever and vomiting
- Blood in stool or vomit
- Pain that persists for more than a few days
- Pain with inability to keep food down
- Abdominal pain during pregnancy

Source: NIH MedlinePlus, Mayo Clinic